

again seeing prices few would have thought possible even in their worst nightmares.

Like most of the players in the market, I too had lost money. But thankfully, it was only a loss on profits. You may find this a bit hard to believe, but I was relieved that my profits had shrunk to more realistic levels. Had I cashed every rupee of profits when my portfolio was at its peak, I would not have known what to do with the money. Many get a kick out of being known as a 'Rs xxx crore net worth fellow'. Not I. This is partly due to fear of attracting the attention of the tax department and the underworld, and partly due to the fear that too much money may blunt my trading skills. I own a portfolio of shares, but have absolutely no delusions about being a value investor and no aspiration to be counted among the investment gurus.

I bought the shares on the recommendations of the people whose wisdom and judgement I trusted. Over the years, my faith in their investment calls would pay off handsomely. Still, trading was what I enjoyed most, and I wanted to be in the game for at least a decade more.

When I told GB all this, he did not take me too seriously.

'Lala, you will be here for a long time, don't worry,' he said in his usual dismissive style.

'Why do you think so?' I asked.

'First, you have managed to stay in business for ten years. That says something about your trading skills. Had you not been a competent trader, the market would have forced you out by now. Second, this profession leaves you unfit for any other trade, because nowhere else can you make or lose lakhs in a day. Perhaps it is not just the money but the excitement, which you cannot find in any other job,' GB said.

The man made sense.

Despite the market crash, it had been a good year for me. I invested in land outside Mumbai, acquired a bigger flat in Ghatkopar and bought myself a red Opel Astra.